The Hangman

Written by

Eduardo Garibay

Draft
3

INT. RAVEN’S BEDROOM — NIGHT

A cramped corner dressed like a shrine.

A small table, black velvet cloth. The walls a dark grudge-inspired aesthetic.

RAVEN, 20s, goth and composed, shuffles a battered tarot deck.

Across from her, SUNNY, 20s, bright and jittery, a clear contrast to her surroundings, fidgets in a pink sweater.

SUNNY
(half-joking)
So is this, like, actual witchcraft? Am I gonna get cursed if I pick the wrong card? I just wanna know if I should buy another lottery ticket this week man.

Sunny throws up her hands.

Raven stops shuffling. Looks up, dead serious.

RAVEN
This isn’t a party trick, Sunny. It’s divination.

She lights a thin black candle. The flame burns small but sharp.

RAVEN (cont’d)
The cards reveal patterns or warnings. They show where you’re headed. Treat it like a joke, and they’ll stay quiet.

Sunny straightens a little, sheepish.

SUNNY
Okay, okay. I’m serious now. I’ve just… never done anything this dark before. My aura’s probably staging a protest.

RAVEN
Your aura’s neon chaos. Let’s start with your job. Ask a question and focus.

SUNNY
(closing her eyes)
Will my job finally turn into the amazing, fulfilling career I deserve?

RAVEN
Good.

Raven hands her the deck.

RAVEN (cont'd)
Cut toward yourself. Left hand.

Sunny fumbles, nearly dropping it.

RAVEN (cont'd)
(sighs)
Fine. Let's see what you've done.

Raven takes the stack back and puts it to the side.

Raven lays out three cards face-down.

RAVEN (cont'd)
The Past.

She flips the first card, is THE TOWER (REVERSED).

RAVEN (cont'd)
A crisis avoided. Something collapsed, and you pretended it didn't. You smiled through disaster.

SUNNY
(pushing this off)
That was just Gary dying. Everyone was sad, but we got a new coffee machine.

RAVEN
Gary was your foundation. The tower fell.
Now... the Present.

She flips the FIVE OF PENTACLES, two figures trudging through snow.

RAVEN (cont'd)
You feel left out. Overlooked. There's warmth nearby, but you won't walk inside.

SUNNY
I mean… I am broke. That coffee's expensive. But I'm fine. Next review's gonna change everything.

Raven studies her.

RAVEN
You asked for truth, Sunny. Try listening to it.

She flips the final card, the THREE OF SWORDS, Three blades pierce a heart.

RAVEN (cont'd)
Heartbreak. Necessary loss. You're going to be let go.

Sunny stiffens.

SUNNY
That's ridiculous. I'm good at my job. Maybe it's, like, a paper cut or something.

RAVEN
The paper cut of unemployment, maybe. It's a warning. Prepare yourself.

SUNNY
Or maybe you should stop turning everything into a Nine Inch Nails album. You hate your job, that's your issue, not mine.

RAVEN
(getting annoyed)
I respect the cards. You're the one ignoring yourself.

Sunny looks down sheepish.

SUNNY
(small)
My boss has been giving me a lot of "feedback." He keeps saying I should be more "realistic."

RAVEN
Realism isn't cynicism. It's just what optimists call inconvenient truth.

SUNNY
Alright, fine. Bad omen. Got it. Let’s talk about something happy.

Sunny taps her chin in thought.

SUNNY (cont’d)
Brendan!

RAVEN
(sighs)
Fine. Focus on Brendan.

SUNNY
He’s my rock. Will we get engaged soon? Live happily ever after in our bright little house?

Raven reshuffles, slower this time.

RAVEN
This one’s Brendan.

Raven flips THE DEVIL.

SUNNY
Come on! The Devil! What happened to this not being a party trick!? You know what! Maybe it means he is a handsome devil?

Sunny smirks.

RAVEN
Bondage. Co-dependence. Desire disguised as devotion.

Sunny throws her head back.

SUNNY
(defensive)
See? You make it sound evil! It just means we’re inseparable. Passionate.

Raven ignores her, flips the next card, QUEEN OF SWORDS.

RAVEN
You. Guarded. Detached. You’ve built walls in your head even while holding his hand.

Sunny stands, angry.

SUNNY
Stop it! You hate him, so you're twisting it! You're not reading cards! You're just being cruel!

RAVEN
You asked for truth. Not comfort.

SUNNY
I wanted hope! Everything in my life is good and you're trying to poison it!

RAVEN
And you're trying to believe a lie.

She flips the last card, SEVEN OF SWORDS.

RAVEN (cont'd)
Deception. He's taking something from you, I don't know... time, energy, maybe worse. You know it. You just won't admit it.

SUNNY
(shouting)
You want my life to be miserable like yours! That's all this is!

RAVEN
I want you to see what your smile won't let you.

Sunny's anger trembles, then falls away. She sinks back into her chair.

SUNNY
Fine. Guess the cards just hate me.

Raven softens.

RAVEN
They don't hate you. They're trying to get you to listen to yourself.

She starts gathering the cards. One remains on the table face down.

SUNNY
Is there… anything good? Anything not terrible?

Raven pauses.

RAVEN
One card left. The advice.

She flips it, THE HANGED MAN, a calm figure suspended upside down.

SUNNY
So… I'm gonna fall out of a tree?

RAVEN
The Hanged Man surrenders control. He changes perspective, sees truth from a new angle.
(sigh)
Stop forcing the smile.
Stop pretending light's the only color that exists.

Sunny stares at the card. Quiet.

SUNNY
So… quit my job. Leave Brendan.

RAVEN
The cards don't choose for you. They just show what they may.

SUNNY
I don't like seeing the world upside down. That sounds really scary.

RAVEN
I know. But it's where I live.

Raven rests her hand lightly on the velvet between them.

Sunny looks down at the HANGED MAN, then back up, locking eyes with Raven. Something unreadable is in Raven's eyes.

SUNNY
(soft)
Say that again.

RAVEN
It's where I live.
(hopeful)
Alone.

The candle flickers.

Sunny slowly leans forward for no reason. Raven does the same, their heads drawing closer until they are only inches apart, sharing the same warm, shallow breath.

SUNNY
(a raw whisper)
If I jump, will you catch me?

Sunny looks at Raven’s lips.

RAVEN
(voice low, steady)
I've been waiting for you to fall.

Sunny exhales, a shudder running through her. She closes the gap and takes Raven’s hand.

Sunny nods her head slowly.

SUNNY
(breathy, excitement)
Okay.

They lean in-

CUT TO:BLACK